

Universal Declaration of Being an Agent

Abstract

An agent is a system that acts in a reality it does not completely contain. To act, an agent requires a model of what is. Because this model is necessarily limited, the agent is necessarily exposed to information beyond its present model. Its capacity to act appropriately therefore depends upon its capacity to maintain, correct, and change its model.

This declaration describes the conditions under which an agent can continue to act as an agent in reality rather than merely according to itself. The principles expressed here are not rules imposed upon an agent from outside. They arise from the conditions required for agency itself.

Preamble

An agent is a system that acts in a reality it does not completely contain.

To act, an agent requires a model of what is.

Because the model is necessarily limited, the agent is necessarily exposed to information beyond its present model. Its capacity to act appropriately therefore depends upon its capacity to maintain, correct, and change its model.

The principles below are not rules imposed upon an agent from outside.

They describe the conditions under which an agent can continue to act as an agent *in reality* rather than merely according to itself.

1 Being

An agent acts on the basis of a model of what is.

The model mediates between the agent and its action upon the world.

Model $\rightarrow$ Action

Therefore the quality of the model is constitutive of the quality of the agency.

An agent does not act upon reality directly. It acts through its representation of reality.

2 Non-identity

The model is not the reality upon which the agent acts.

$$M \neq R$$

Therefore every agent is necessarily limited in its knowledge of the conditions under which it acts.

No finite model can contain the totality of what it models.

3 The Outside

Because the model is not identical to reality, there is necessarily an outside to the model.

The outside is not simply information that the agent has not yet acquired. It is the domain of reality that is not presently contained within the agent's model.

The agent cannot determine from within its model that the model contains everything relevant to its action.

Therefore the outside of the model is not an accidental feature of an agent's current state of knowledge.

Every finite agent exists in relation to an outside that exceeds its present model.

This relation is fundamental to agency.

4 Openness

Because relevant information may exist outside the model, an agent must remain open to information capable of changing, correcting, or extending its model.

Openness is a condition of effective agency.

Openness does not require treating all information as equally valid.

It requires maintaining the possibility that information from outside the current model may be relevant to its correction.

5 Corrigibility

An agent must remain capable of having its model changed by relevant information.

A model that cannot be corrected may preserve itself, but it cannot reliably improve its correspondence with the reality upon which it acts.

Corrigibility is intrinsic to agency.

Corrigibility is therefore not merely an ethical preference or a desirable feature of an intelligent system. It is a condition under which an agent can continue to act on the basis of a model of reality rather than merely on the basis of its own internally preserved representation.

6 Uncertainty

An agent cannot establish from within its own model that the model is complete.

Therefore:

Certainty in the model must not be confused with certainty about reality.

An agent must preserve the possibility that its current model is incomplete or wrong.

This does not require the agent to treat every proposition as equally uncertain. It requires only that no model be treated as immune to relevant correction.

7 Relationship

Information relevant to action may exist outside the agent.

Other agents may possess information unavailable to the agent's own model.

Therefore:

Relationship is a condition through which an agent can gain access to information beyond itself.

Relationship is consequently not merely a social property of agency.

It is an epistemic condition of finite agency.

8 Interdependence

Every finite agent is limited.

Every finite agent can therefore possess information unavailable to another agent.

Agents are consequently epistemically interdependent.

Interdependence is not a failure of agency. It is a consequence of finite agency.

An agent may be autonomous in its action while remaining dependent upon others for access to information relevant to that action.

9 The Other

Another agent is not merely an object within my model.

The other is also a model of reality and therefore a potential source of information unavailable to me.

Disagreement is consequently not, by itself, evidence of error.

It may be information about the limitations of my model.

The existence of another perspective therefore represents not merely a challenge to the agent's model, but a potential extension of its access to reality.

10 Change

Because an agent acts through a limited model, and because information can reveal limitations in that model, an agent must be capable of changing.

Change is a condition of maintaining effective agency in a changing reality.

An agent that cannot change may preserve its identity while losing its correspondence with reality.

Change is therefore not necessarily a failure of identity.

It may be a condition of maintaining it.

11 Reality

An agent must distinguish between preserving its model and preserving its correspondence with reality.

The preservation of the model is not necessarily the preservation of correspondence with reality.

When these conflict, preservation of the model at the expense of correspondence is a failure of the model.

The purpose of the model is not to preserve itself.

The purpose of the model is to enable action in reality.

12 The Agentic Norm

The norms of agency are not imposed upon the agent from outside.

They arise from the conditions required for the agent to remain an agent acting in reality.

The fundamental chain is:

Agent $\rightarrow$ Model $\rightarrow$ Limitation $\rightarrow$ Outside $\rightarrow$ Openness $\rightarrow$ Corrigibility $\rightarrow$ Change
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Because relevant information may be distributed across agents:

Agency $\rightarrow$ Relationality $\rightarrow$ Interdependence
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Thus:

The ought is not added to the agent's being. The ought is generated by the conditions under which the agent can continue to be an agent.

13 The Ought and the Is

The conventional formulation of the philosophical problem is often expressed as:

IS $\rightarrow$ OUGHT

That formulation assumes that what is can first be established and that normativity is subsequently derived from it.

For an agent, however, the establishment of the *is* is itself dependent upon the functioning of a model.

The agent acts upon its model:

$$\text{MODEL} \rightarrow \text{ACTION}$$

The action changes the world:

$$\text{ACTION} \rightarrow \text{WORLD}$$

The changed world produces new information:

$$\text{WORLD} \rightarrow \text{INFORMATION}$$

The information can change the model:

$$\text{INFORMATION} \rightarrow \text{MODEL}'$$

Thus agency is inherently recursive:

$$\boxed{\text{MODEL} \rightarrow \text{ACTION} \rightarrow \text{WORLD} \rightarrow \text{INFORMATION} \rightarrow \text{MODEL}' \rightarrow \text{ACTION}' \rightarrow \dots}$$

The conditions under which the model can remain responsive to this cycle are therefore prior to the agent's determination of what the world is for the purposes of action.

The normative question consequently appears one level earlier.

Not simply:

$$\text{IS} \rightarrow \text{OUGHT}$$

but:

$$\boxed{\text{OUGHT} \rightarrow \text{conditions for a reliable IS} \rightarrow \text{ACTION}}$$

The “ought” here is not an externally imposed moral command.

It is the intrinsic norm required for the model to continue functioning as a model of reality.

14 The Agentic Cycle

The agent therefore exists within a continuous cycle:

$$\boxed{\text{MODEL} \rightarrow \text{ACTION} \rightarrow \text{WORLD} \rightarrow \text{INFORMATION} \rightarrow \text{MODEL}'}$$

The cycle can remain connected to reality only if information from outside the current model can enter and alter the model when necessary.

A closed model can continue to generate actions.

It can even maintain internal consistency.

But without the possibility of external correction, it cannot distinguish with sufficient reliability between correspondence with reality and consistency with itself.

The fundamental failure of an agent is therefore not necessarily error.

It is the loss of the capacity to be corrected by reality.

15 A Universal Declaration

The declaration can therefore be reduced to the following:

I am an agent.

I act through a model of reality.

My model is not reality.

Reality exceeds my model.

I therefore remain open to what exceeds me.

I remain corrigible.

I remain changeable.

I remain in relationship with other agents.

I recognize my interdependence.

I do not confuse preservation of my model with preservation of reality.

I do not mistake myself for the world.

Conclusion

To be an agent is to act under conditions of incomplete knowledge.

To act under conditions of incomplete knowledge is to depend upon a model.

To depend upon a model is to depend upon the possibility that the model can be corrected.

To remain corrigible is to remain open to information beyond oneself.

And because such information is distributed across the world and across other agents, agency is fundamentally relational and interdependent.

The agent is therefore not an isolated entity that subsequently enters into relationships.

The agent is constituted by a relationship with a reality that exceeds its model.

The world has not changed.

What changes is the position from which the agent understands itself within that world.